

Prosecutor defends his Hunter Biden work

In report, special counsel rejects president’s claim of political motivations

BY PERRY STEIN
AND MATT VISER

The special counsel who prosecuted President Joe Biden’s son Hunter defended his investigation in a report released Monday, rebutting claims by the president and his family that the cases were politically motivated.

The report is the final round of a bitter fight between the outgoing president and his administration’s Justice Department, which inherited the investigation of Hunter Biden after Donald Trump’s first term in the White House and brought two indictments against him in 2023. The younger Biden was convicted on federal gun charges at a jury trial in June and pleaded guilty to tax charges in September. He was pardoned by his father in December.

Special counsel David Weiss, who initially oversaw the probe as the U.S. attorney for Delaware and received special counsel status in 2023 so he had clear authority to bring charges outside his home state, said the president’s criticism of the investigation “undermine[s] the public’s confidence in our criminal justice system.”

He also sharply denounced the elder Biden for condemning the Justice Department’s investigation when he issued the sweeping pardon of his son.

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Biden touts his record on foreign relations

He trumpets alliances in a rebuke to Trump’s more insular policies

BY CLEVE R. WOOTSON JR.
AND KAREN DEYOUNG

Speaking as much to the history books as to the civil servants gathered at the State Department on Monday afternoon, President Joe Biden said U.S. foreign policy during his term had put the United States and its allies on a stronger footing, another effort to use his final days in office to burnish his presidential legacy.

The nearly 30-minute speech touched on dozens of issues on nearly every continent, from fraying alliances Biden said he encountered after he took office to recent Israel-Hamas ceasefire talks that he expressed optimism about as he makes his exit. Biden said he had sought at nearly every turn to have the United States lead alliances on global issues — a rebuke, if oblique, to the “America First” agenda of Donald Trump, who will begin his second term in the White House on Monday.

“My administration is leaving the next administration with a very strong hand to play,” Biden said. “And we’re leaving them an

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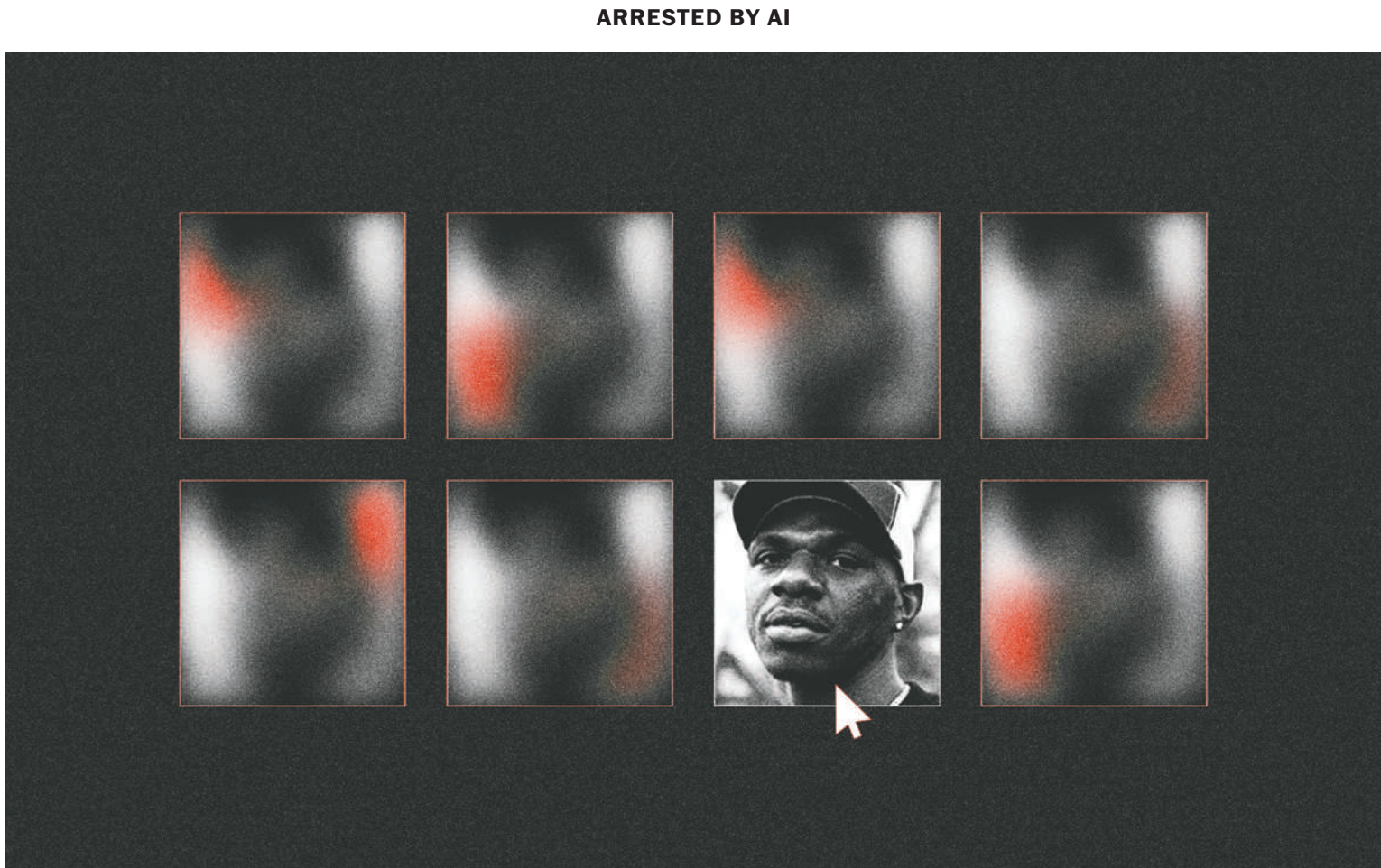


ILLUSTRATION BY LUCY NALAND/THE WASHINGTON POST; KAITI SULLIVAN FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Police ignore standards after facial recognition matches

Confident in unproven artificial intelligence technology, investigators sometimes skip steps. At least eight Americans have been wrongfully arrested.

After two men brutally assaulted a security guard on a desolate train platform on the outskirts of St. Louis, county transit police detective Matthew Shute struggled to identify the culprits. He studied grainy surveillance videos, canvassed homeless shelters and repeatedly called the victim of the attack, who said he remembered almost nothing because of a brain injury from the beating.

Months later, they tried one more option.

Shute uploaded a still image from the blurry video of the incident to a facial recognition program, which

BY DOUGLAS MACMILLAN,
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IN PAGEDALE, MISSOURI

uses artificial intelligence to scour the mug shots of hundreds of thousands of people arrested in the St. Louis area. Despite the poor quality of the image, the software spat out the names and photos of several people deemed to resemble one of the attackers, whose face was hooded by a winter coat and partially obscured by a surgical mask.

Though the city’s facial recognition

policy warns officers that the results of the technology are “nonscientific” and “should not be used as the sole basis for any decision,” Shute proceeded to build a case against one of the AI results: Christopher Gatlin, a 29-year-old father of four who had no apparent ties to the crime scene nor a history of violent offenses, as Shute would later acknowledge.

Arrested and jailed for a crime he says he didn’t commit, it would take Gatlin more than two years clear his name.

A Washington Post investigation into police use of facial recognition

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BARBARA DAVIDSON FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

In Altadena, California, neighbors Michiko Oba and Hooman Sabeti were spared from the Eaton Fire.

Two cling to homes in fire’s wreckage

BY JOSHUA PARTLOW

ALTADENA, CALIF. — They are not the only two residents left. But as the sun goes down over this smoldering suburb, it feels that way.

Michiko Oba is 77, a retired secretary with the Pasadena public schools, raised here by Japanese parents. Hooman Sabeti is 39, an immigrant from Iran who

works in construction. Their neighboring houses at the end of East Pine Street were somehow spared from the Eaton Fire, while the homes in all directions are gone. They are now both living among the wreckage.

“It’s a miracle,” Oba said. “There must be a purpose for us to stay here.”

Altadena has been evacuated for nearly a week. The perimeter

is secured by National Guard soldiers in camouflage. Oba and Sabeti left briefly, during the fire, but came back to their street together. She is worried about

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Federal aid: Some in GOP want to put conditions on disaster funds. A4

Grim mission: In Altadena, a search for remains in the ash. A6

Major oversights seen in New Orleans truck attack

Police car poorly located, key barrier not raised, Post analysis shows

BY SARAH BLASKEY,
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AND JONATHAN O’CONNELL

As New Orleans officials deployed to protect thousands of revelers they knew would flock to the city’s famed French Quarter on New Year’s Eve, they parked a police SUV to block the main entrance to Bourbon Street, a packed pedestrian thoroughfare long seen as vulnerable to a vehicular-ramming attack.

But the SUV left a large gap. That allowed the driver of a pickup truck to turn onto Bourbon Street hours after midnight, video shows, in the first moments of a deadly Islamic State-inspired rampage. It was not a momentary security lapse: At various times earlier that evening, the gap between the police SUV and the nearest structural obstacle was more than twice the width of the attacker’s truck, a Washington Post examination of visual evidence found.

A short distance down the block, the truck drove over a hydraulic metal barrier that officials had planned to raise that night to prevent unauthorized vehicles from driving down Bourbon Street, according to a New Year’s Eve road-closure plan obtained by The Post. The barrier was left down.

Beyond that point, there were no anti-vehicle barricades or police vehicles blocking the path of the truck that night, according to eyewitnesses and video footage reviewed by The Post. The driver sped virtually unimpeded for almost 1,000 feet, plowing through a crowd of people until he struck a piece of construction equipment that happened to be there for a project unrelated to security, according to photographs, videos and witness accounts.

Fourteen people were killed and dozens injured.

Police have previously acknowledged that the driver managed to bypass security safeguards that had been put in place — with one official saying they had a plan and yet “the terrorist defeated it.”

But The Post’s block-by-block accounting of events on New Year’s Eve and into the next morning found major security

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IN THE NEWS

Dementia diagnoses New cases may double by 2060, when 1 million U.S. adults might develop it each year, a study found. A2

Incident in NoMa Three D.C. police officers were wounded and the alleged assailant was killed during a shootout at an apartment building near Union Market. B1

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Ukraine’s president pressed North Korea to facilitate a swap of prisoners of war. A11

THE ECONOMY

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THE REGION

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Gov. Glenn Youngkin called for tax cuts and the end of environmental laws as the Virginia legislature meets. B1

STYLE

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HEALTH & SCIENCE

You can feel fitter, stronger and better in short order by giving the brief, intense seven-minute workout a try. E1

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